
This Is the Week J.D. Vance Became Vice President

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[Sign up for the Surge](#), the newsletter that covers the most important political nonsense of the week, delivered to your inbox every Saturday.

Welcome to this week's edition of the Surge, a very special Friday Federal Holiday edition that makes a great reading companion to your [steak-and-sauerkraut breakfast](#).

The United States and Iran have agreed at last on a framework for a deal to end the war, a tremendous success for Trump if it works and a total failure for J.D. Vance if it doesn't. We also check in on some of this week's primary results—in which a prominent Trump endorsee lost—and consider Trump's gleaming gunk pool on the National Mall.

Before we get rolling, we want to plug Slate's revamped daily Slatest newsletter, in which Slate's Ian Prasad Philbrick breaks down the biggest news story of the day. [Sign up here](#).

To Iran!

1.

J.D. Vance

Ready to perform his vice presidential duties: Eating the blame.

The release of the administration's memorandum of understanding with Iran was greeted with sharp pushback from Iran hawks. We don't get it: Wasn't it actually pretty nice of the Iranians to offer a *conditional* surrender after defeating the U.S. in the war? If finalized, the MOU would offer Iran \$300 billion for reconstruction, unfrozen funds, the cessation of sanctions, and more in exchange for a down-blending of their existing nuclear material and a return to the status quo ante in the Strait of Hormuz. This led GOP Sen. Bill Cassidy to describe the Iran war as "the worst foreign policy blunder in decades."

But while Cassidy, who lost his primary, has the political space to voice his true feelings, most other Republicans are still too in thrall to Trump to say that he biffed it. Fortunately, there's a constitutional position that serves as a political blame receptacle: the vice president. J.D.

Vance has served point on these negotiations, and should the final deal even closely resemble the MOU, he's going to hear about it. South Carolina Sen.

Lindsey Graham has [put Vance](#) on notice, and other [GOP senators say they are eager](#) to hear him defend the deal. On the other hand, Vance already [has been selling the deal](#) in anti-war terms as he seeks to shore up ties with elements of the MAGA coalition turned off by Trump's militarism.

Take it from Trump himself. At the G7 summit this week, Trump [said of the deal](#), "If it works out, I'm going to take the credit. If it doesn't work out, I'm blaming J.D. You better be careful, J.D. He's gonna turn his plane around and get the hell out of here." He said this in a joking, busting-his-chops way. (Secretary of State Marco Rubio stood stone-faced behind Trump's shoulder.) But rest

assured, he will say it in a quite serious way if the time comes. Anyway, [congrats to the veep on his book](#), for which he is on a publicity tour while also negotiating the end of a war.

2.

Jay Clayton

Trump delaying his own nominee's confirmation for ... reasons.

Trump's nominee to be the permanent new director of national intelligence was delayed on Wednesday because ... Trump decided to delay him. Posting from Europe, Trump [directed](#) Clayton not to attend his own confirmation hearing on Wednesday, ostensibly because he wanted Clayton's replacement as a prosecutor confirmed first. That means that mortgage-application-sleuth Bill Pulte remains as acting DNI, even though Democrats have been quite clear that they won't reauthorize warrantless wiretapping powers so long as that's the case.

What the hell is going on here? "Good question," Senate Majority Leader John Thune said about why Trump was delaying his own nominee's confirmation and alongside it reauthorization of a program the administration deems vital. Some suggested that he was creating a little bit of a news-cycle distraction just as the terms of the Iran MOU were about to drop. There's merit to that.

But consider another demand he made in the same more-incomprehensible-than-normal screed in which he directed Clayton not to attend his hearing. Trump says he won't sign the reauthorized surveillance law unless the SAVE America Act, the GOP's elections bill that does not and will not ever have the votes, is attached to it. This is a continuation, then, of the feud between Trump and Senate Republicans, who have pushed back on Trump against ballroom funding, his DOJ slush fund, the Pulte nomination, and his demands that the filibuster be nuked or the Senate parliamentarian fired. He's mad at them, and so he's fucking with them.

3.

Pesky algae blooms

Can no amount of poison clean this slime hole?

President Trump made quick work of his \$14 million renovation and repainting of the Lincoln Memorial Reflecting Pool after decrying how it had been "filthy" and "disgusting," and promising to restore it with "clean, beautiful water." Only a few days after the pool was refilled, though, it reverted what it always is: a filthy slime pit that nevertheless does an adequate job of its primary objective: reflecting.

And so it was a delightful week of watching the Interior Department scramble to gussy it up again. Workers were seen dumping hydrogen peroxide along the pool's perimeter, which *did* clear up the

water along the perimeter. Waders with nets worked their way through the massive body of water, as if this were a little backyard pool with some tree debris. Chunks of Trump's beloved "American flag blue" paint job are [surfacing](#). The administration is arguing that in the long run, the [pool's new filtration system](#)—"advanced nanobubbler technology," per the administration—will defeat the green goop outbreaks. In the meantime, Trump's work beautifying this particular part of Washington, D.C., has resulted in a trash pool and some [charred-looking acres of grass](#) near the Washington Monument where the numbers "8647"—the most [felonious](#) combination of numbers out there—had been inscribed.

4.

Rick Jackson

A Trump endorsee goes down.

Trump and outgoing Georgia Gov. Brian Kemp are frequently at odds. Kemp dumped all of his political capital into support for former football coach Derek Dooley in the state's Senate primary; Trump was behind Rep. Mike Collins. (Collins won the runoff this week.) Trump also, memorably, tried to take out Kemp himself in 2022 by endorsing former Sen. David Perdue; Kemp decisively beat back the challenge. But in the governor's race this year, Kemp and Trump were aligned behind Lt. Gov. Burt Jones, a businessman who was deeply involved in Trump's efforts to overturn the presidential election in the state in 2020.

It was quite an upset, then, when Jones lost the gubernatorial runoff this week to Rick Jackson, a billionaire healthcare services executive who dumped \$100 million of his own money into the race. Jackson will now face former Atlanta Mayor Keisha Lance Bottoms in the November general election. It stings Trump whenever one of his endorsees loses a primary. But when it does happen, he offers the same justification: that the other candidate [only won by embracing Trump](#) and showing servility to his brand. In this case, he's [not wrong](#).

5.

Susan Collins

Checking in on the race (but mostly plugging our feature).

The Surge was [pleased to publish a quick li'l 4,000-plus-word opus](#) this week on Sen. Susan Collins and what makes her such a tough opponent. The short answer is that she was arguably the best in the Senate at delivering dollars to her home state *before* she became chairwoman of the Senate Appropriations Committee, and now she's pitching her perch atop that panel as a "once-in-century" opportunity for Maine. Democrats working to oust her should not underestimate the strength of this argument as undecided voters, even those who don't really like her, make up their minds in the last weeks before the election.

Even with that, though, these are the most difficult conditions she's ever run in—the most polarized environment, in a blue state, in an anti-Republican cycle. A tsunami would spare no one, and the polls this spring showing her Democratic opponent, Graham Platner, leading her by 6 or 7 points passed the smell test. Since fresh waves of bad press against Platner came out over the last month, though, he's taken a noticeable hit in the polling. Two polls [released](#) this week showed Platner up by 1 point and 2 points, respectively. It's incredibly difficult to game this out—so we won't. But while Democrats went into this cycle thinking they'd finally summoned the perfect conditions for ousting Collins, they could have instead provided her the perfect opponent for earning an unlikely additional term.

6.

Kash Patel

He will never stop posting.

In the aftermath of last fall's assassination of Charlie Kirk, FBI Director Kash Patel earned a fair amount of grief from both inside and outside the administration for [prematurely posting updates on the case](#) to social media—including, at one point, suggesting that they had the right guy in custody when they did not. It was one of the first instances in which his lack of experience for the position revealed itself, and ever since, a new questionable decision—chugging beers at the Olympics, scuba diving at a war memorial, etc.—seems to pop up with regularity.

This week, Patel once again couldn't contain himself from posting. Patel announced early Tuesday morning, coinciding with a leak of the news to Fox News, that the FBI had disrupted an alleged terror plot to attack last week's UFC fight at the White House. As NBC News and others [reported](#), the announcement took some in law enforcement by surprise because the investigation was still ongoing and "there were still people being rounded up on a sealed federal case." The Secret Service was overtly upset about it, with the deputy director telling the press that the agency "led that investigation from the beginning," that it was ongoing, and that "in order to maintain the integrity of the investigation and the security plan, we chose not to leak it." Ouch.

7.

Jackson Lahmeyer

Felled by the British Tabloids.

Jackson Lahmeyer is a MAGA megachurch pastor from Tulsa who founded the group Pastors for Trump. He advanced to a runoff in an Oklahoma congressional primary this week, and then some unfortunate news broke about him. The Surge recognizes that this will be shocking to hear, but here goes: The founder of "Pastors for Trump" was sending sexy texts with a woman who was not his wife, according to a Daily Mail story this week. It's almost too stunning to carry on after hearing

such news—but to a second paragraph of this entry we must go.

Lahmeyer had been endorsed by Trump, a fellow man of God, ahead of the primary. But once the news dropped, Trump could no longer morally stomach supporting someone who would play so fast and loose with the holy rite of marriage. So after Trump switched his endorsement to state lawmaker Mark Tedford, Lahmeyer dropped out. We appreciated, though, Lahmeyer's last-ditch effort to salvage himself by attempting anti-British nativism to defend himself against the Daily Mail, [posting](#) that "the British Tabloid tried to paint me out in a way which is not the case." He has since deleted his Twitter account, and his fate rests with the Lord. Enjoy the World Cup this weekend!

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